WSDC 2024

SERBIA

BID DOCUMENT

LETTER FROM CONVENORS

Dear esteemed members of the WSDC community,

It is with great excitement and enthusiasm that we, representatives of Open Communication, present our bid to host the World Schools Debate Championship in Serbia in 2024. As a debate organization with 25 years of experience, we have had the pleasure of organizing numerous major debate tournaments, including two European Universities Debating Championships held in Serbia (Belgrade 2012 and Novi Sad 2018) as well as the online Belgrade World Universities Debating Championship in 2022.

As we embark on this bid process, we hope to showcase our commitment to promoting and advancing the art of debate in Serbia. Our aim is for the WSDC in Serbia to be a trailblazing event, paving the way for making Serbian debate in the World schools debate format just as successful as the highly esteemed university debate. We believe that debate is a valuable educational tool, one that fosters critical thinking, effective communication, and the ability to engage in productive dialogue with others. By hosting the WSDC, we hope to promote these values in the wider community and inspire the next generation of debaters.

Our experience in organizing university as well as high school level debate tournaments has equipped us with the necessary skills and resources to deliver an exceptional event. We are committed to delivering a WSDC that will be up to the organizational standards we showcased during large international debate competitions we have hosted in the past, while at the same time adapting to the needs and expectations of the WSDC community and high school competitors from very diverse backgrounds. Our team has a deep understanding of the logistics involved in organizing such a large-scale event, from transportation and accommodation to tournament scheduling and adjudication. We are confident in our ability to create a welcoming and hospitable environment for all participants and spectators, and to deliver an outstanding debate experience.

We also recognize that hosting the WSDC is an incredible opportunity to showcase the beauty and cultural richness of Serbia. Our country has a long and proud tradition of hospitality, and we are excited to share our culture, food, and history with the wider debate community. We hope to create an unforgettable experience that will not only be memorable for participants but also leave a lasting impact on the development of debate in Serbia.

In closing, we thank you for considering our bid to host the World Schools Debate Championship in Serbia in 2024. We are excited about the prospect of bringing this prestigious event to our country, and we look forward to working with the WSDC community to make it a resounding success.

Sincerely,
Predrag Pijevčević, Convenor and Mila Marjanović, Co-convenor of WSDC Serbia 2024

LETTER FROM CHIEF ADJUDICATORS

Dear WSDC Community,

We are writing to express our deep appreciation for the opportunity to serve as the Co-Chief Adjudicators for the Serbia World Schools Debating Championship 2024 bid. It would be an honour to give back to a community that has been such an integral part of our lives.

With almost a decade of experience in WSDC, we are confident that we possess the qualifications and devotion necessary to fulfil this role effectively. We have a comprehensive understanding of the varying demands of each position within WSDC, having previously served as speakers, coaches, judges, and DCAs in past tournaments. Moreover, our success in the university circuit - including as an EUDC ESL Champion, a WUDC Open Semi Finalist and EUDC Open Semi Finalists - has equipped us with the skills and experience necessary to help others develop as debaters and judges. Furthermore, we are committed to respecting and learning from the experience of our advisors and other members of the community, given our belief in the importance of learning from the experience and knowledge of previous generations.

We recognize the challenges faced by many countries in developing their domestic debating circuits, and support the recent efforts to expand WSDC to new nations. Our experience in a variety of national circuits has provided us with a deep understanding of the barriers faced by nations as debating moves back offline, as well as the positive impact that online tournaments have had on increasing accessibility to the WSDC format. It is our firm belief in the value of international collaboration that frames our desire to increase access and training globally, through an expanded outreach and coaching programme in the lead up 2024. Moreover we appreciate the need to expand existing judge training workshops, to ensure that as adjudication rules develop, the understanding and skills of our judges follow suit.

The success of the Serbian university circuit has been a source of inspiration for generations of aspiring debaters across the Balkans and forms a solid foundation for the future growth of the budding WSDC community in the country. We firmly believe that bringing the WSDC to Serbia will provide an opportunity for partnerships and collaboration across the entire region, and we would be honoured to play a role in that. Our extensive collaboration with the Serbian debate community has given us a firsthand appreciation of the potential of WSDC debating in the country, and we can attest to the professionalism, passion, and commitment of Predrag, Mila, and the rest of the Organising Committee.

WSDC has had a profound impact on our lives, providing us with a platform for personal and intellectual growth as well as the chance to contribute to the education and development of young people, something we are both deeply passionate about. We understand the importance of this tournament for competitors and nations alike, and we would be privileged to contribute to a community that has given us so much.

Sincerely,
Rok Hafner and Geneva Roy

BID AT A GLANCE

- 16-26 July 2024 in Belgrade
- Chief Adjudicators - Rok Hafner and Geneva Roy
- Convenor - Predrag Pijevčević
- Co-convenor - Mila Marjanović
- Accommodation - Crowne Plaza Belgrade
- Venue - Faculty of Organizational Sciences Belgrade
- Registration fee - 800 EUR per person

WHY BELGRADE?

Belgrade is an enchanting city that has played a significant role in the history of the Balkans and beyond, serving as a crossroads of civilizations for centuries. Today, it is a bustling and diverse metropolis that boasts a wealth of cultural, historical, and artistic attractions, from majestic landmarks and galleries to mouth-watering gastronomy and stunning natural scenery. Centrally located, Belgrade is easily accessible from all corners of Europe, making it an ideal destination for travelers seeking an unforgettable experience. Most notably, Belgrade is renowned for its warm and welcoming spirit, embodying the Serbian hospitality that leaves a lasting impression on every visitor.

ORGANIZATION BEHIND BID

Open Communication

WHO ARE WE

Open Communication is an academic debating network devoted to improving the culture of dialogue. It was founded in 1997 by students and professors at the University of Belgrade and modeled after debate clubs at prestigious European university centers. So far, more than 1500 students and high school pupils have completed its educational programs in debate, communication skills, critical thinking, argumentation, case-building and public speaking. We also organized or been part of organization of various major debate tournaments: Belgrade EUDC 2012, Zagreb EUDC 2014, Novi Sad EUDC 2018, Belgrade WUDC 2022, and Zagreb EUDC 2022.

The mission of founders was to promote critical thinking, the culture of peaceful dialogue and tolerance in conservative society like Serbian was then, while now-days' goals moved further to integrating Serbia in European and world's debate land and implementing variety of projects with educational and debate-oriented goals in Serbia and Western Balkans region.

Beside different courses and workshops intended for debaters, the organization is offering programmes for professors, accredited by Ministry of Education, Science and Technological Development, based on promotion of debate as a teaching method.

Within conducted local and international projects, Open Communication has established great cooperation with state and local authorities, regional partner organizations in Western Balkans and gathered the support of the Delegation of the European Union to the Republic of Serbia, especially through projects "European School of Debate", "Historija, istorija, povijest - Lessons for Today" and "Model International Criminal Court - Western Balkans".

Under these partnerships, Open Communication expressed itself as an important local contributor to the Euro-integration process, through provoking relevant public discussion and educating youth in the manner of tolerance and other social values that the European Union is nurturing and encouraging in candidate states.

OUR MISSION

As we continue our work promoting critical thinking, we are also shifting our focus to the World Schools format, which we believe is more appropriate for high school students than BP. To gain experience and build relationships with other members of the global debate community, we sent delegations to previous WSDCs, including WSDC Croatia and Slovenia 2018 and Online WSDC 2020. We are also proud to have members of OrgComm and CA team from Croatian and Slovenian Debate Societies who bring their vast experience in the World Schools format to our team. With our commitment to promoting debate and critical thinking and our experience in organizing and participating in major debate tournaments, we are confident in our ability to organize an exceptional WSDC in Serbia in 2024.

PROVISIONAL SCHEDULE

TUESDAY 16TH JULY	Arrivals and registration
WEDNESDAY 17TH JULY	Briefings and Opening ceremony
THURSDAY 18TH JULY	Rounds 1 & 2
FRIDAY 19TH JULY	Rounds 3 & 4
SATURDAY 20TH JULY	Tours and activities
SUNDAY 21ST JULY	Rounds 5 & 6
MONDAY 22ND JULY	Rounds 7 & 8 and Break night ceremony
TUESDAY 23RD JULY	Partial Double Octofinals & Octofinals
WEDNESDAY 24TH JULY	Quarterfinals and Semifinals
THURSDAY 25TH JULY	Grand Final and Closing ceremony
FRIDAY 26TH JULY	Departures

CHIEF ADJUDICATORS

ROK HAFNER (SLOVENIA) - CHIEF ADJUDICATOR

Rok is currently employed at Za in proti, zavod za kulturo dialoga, the Slovenian national debate organisation and is pursuing a Masters degree in International relations at the University of Ljubljana.

He has been involved in debating since 2012 and has attended the WSDC for the first time in 2015 in Singapore, where he represented Team Slovenia and was the 4th best EFL speaker at the tournament. In the following years remained deeply involved with World Schools debating , teams coached by him have won the International World Schools Debate Tournament Ljutomer in 2020, International Debate Competition Valencia 2023 and spoken in the finals of Winter Holidays Open Zagreb 2019. At the WSDC Macau 2021, he was the co-coach of Team Turkey and he is coaching Team Slovenia for WSDC Vietnam 2023.

He has judged the semi-finals of WSDC Netherlands 2022 and was a CA at more than 30 tournaments, including at some of the largest schools competitions in Europe: International World Schools Debate Tournament Ljutomer (2022 and 2023), Eurasian Schools Debating Championship 2021, Winter Holidays Open 2021, and Nordic Schools Debating Championship 2022.

As a university debater, he was the ESL champion at the EUDC Madrid 2021 and an Open semi-finalist at the EUDC Athens 2019 and paneled the ESL finals of the EUDC 2022 in Zagreb.

GENEVA ROY (NEW ZEALAND) - CHIEF ADJUDICATOR

Geneva is a current law student at the University of London, having previously completed a Bachelor's degree in Philosophy, Politics, and Economics at the University of Oxford. With an impressive background in debating since 2013, she currently serves as the Chairperson of the WSDC Board of Directors.

In 2017, Geneva was the captain of the New Zealand team at WSDC, and during her university years, she has achieved significant success as a debater, reaching the semi-finals at both Bangkok WUDC 2020 and Athens EUDC 2019. As a judge, she has been a DCA of both Vietnam WSDC 2023 and Macau WSDC 2021, and has judged the WSDC Grand Final in 2019, 2021 and 22. She has also served as a CA of tournaments across four continents, including the Harvard WSDC Invitational 2022, Oxford WSDC 2021, Auckland Seasonals 2018, Argo Open 2021, DSDC 2021, Nordic Schools Debating 2020 Championship and Singapore Pre-WSDC 2021. Geneva is also the CA of Glasgow EUDC 2023, DCA of Black Sea EUDC 2022, and has judged the ESL Final of Belgrade WUDC 2022.

Furthermore, Geneva has extensive experience in organizing tournaments, having served as the Convenor of the New Zealand National Schools Debating Championship, Oxford Schools, and Oxford IV. She also served as an equity officer for both school and university tournaments and was a former Head of Oxford Debating. Finally, Geneva has significant coaching experience, having been the training officer at WUDC, coached WSDC Auckland development squad, and top Oxford debating teams.

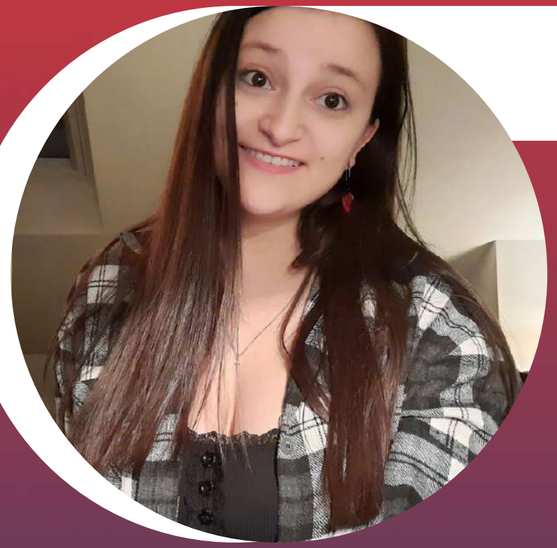
CONVENORS

PREDRAG PIJEVČEVIĆ (SERBIA) - CONVENOR

Predrag is a final-year law student currently working as an intern at the Ministry of Foreign Affairs of Serbia. He's been debating since 2016 and has been involved in the debating community in practically every single role. He was the convener of multiple high school debate competitions in Serbia, as well as one of the largest debate competitions for high school students in the Balkans, Decembarac. Recently, he has served on the Org Comm of the Zagreb EUDC 2022 and International Worlds Schools Debate Tournament Ljutomer 2023.

He got into debating through WSDC having represented Serbia at the WSDC in 2018 which inspired him to become an established speaker in the Balkan university debate circuit as well as a judge, breaking at several regional debate competitions in both BP and WSDC debate formats.

Predrag is committed to passing on his debate skills and knowledge and to developing the local debate circuit, demonstrating that with being a coach to young debaters from his grammar school and Faculty of Law year since 2017 and serving as the coach of Team Serbia at the Online WSDC 2022. He was a member of the tabulation teams in the majority of domestic BP tournaments and as well as at Split Open 2022, Winter Holidays Open Zagreb 2022, and Paris World Schools Tournament 2023.



MILA MARJANOVIĆ (SERBIA) - CO-CONVENOR

Mila Marjanović has a Bachelor’s degree in Law and is currently getting her Master’s degree in Environmental Law from the University of Belgrade as well as working as a court intern at The First Basic Court in Belgrade.

Mila's involvement in debate began in 2015, and since then, she has accumulated a broad amount of experience in all aspects of debate tournaments. From serving as a debater and debate trainer to moving on to the organizational side of debate tournaments and eventually serving as a convenor. She has been a member of Open Communication since 2015, working as a part of its PR team and eventually becoming its coordinator in 2017 and an executive board member in 2019.

She was a member of the PR team for the Novi Sad EUDC 2018 and contributed to its success. The tournament, being bring organized in record time, was a major achievement. She has also served as a convenor on multiple tournaments in Serbia and the region including tournaments like Belgrade Open (international debate tournament, 50 teams) and Decembarac. One of her greatest achievements came when Open Communication was given the honor to host WUDC in 2022, where she served as the tournament director, registration officer and PR coordinator. During the process of organizing Belgrade WUDC, which hosted 400 teams, some of her responsibilities were making sure that the registration process went smoothly, addressing all the issues that institutions had during the registration process, designing the posts for social media, coordinating the volunteers, working on logistic tasks during the tournament etc.

Aside from her work in debate, Mila is also a member of the Project team in Open Communication. As a trainer on various international projects, she has had the opportunity to work with high school students from all over the world.

ORG COMM

ALMA DŽAFIĆ (CROATIA) - REGISTRATION OFFICER

Alma currently works as a project assistant at Croatian Debate Society (HDD). Having started debating in 2015, she attended WSDC in 2017 & 2018 as a debater and was part of the Org Team for The Netherlands Online WSDC 2022. In addition to her WSDC experience, she has judged at pretty much all Croatian tournaments since 2018 and organizes a number of them every year. She was also one of the organizers of Winter Holidays Open in 2021 and 2022.

Dragan Dživdžmanović is a Bachelor of Macro Economic Analysis and Policy who is currently pursuing a Master's degree in Banking and Financial Management at the University of Belgrade. He started debating in 2016 and participated in WSDC in 2018 as a debater, along with two BP European Championships in 2019 and 2022. Dragan was also the President and Coordinator of the Debate Club at the Faculty of Economics and a member of the Student Parliament, Case Study Club, and Tax Consultancy Intern at KPMG. Currently, he works as a Junior Researcher in the Department of Macroeconomic Analysis at the National Bank of Serbia, focusing on Central Banking and Monetary Policy.

DRAGAN DŽIVDŽANOVIĆ (SERBIA) - BUDGET OFFICER

KATARINA LAZIĆ (SERBIA) – SPONSORSHIP OFFICER

Katarina has graduated from the Faculty of Organisational Sciences, Department of Informational Systems and technologies at the University of Belgrade. She has been involved in competitive debating since 2019, and in that time she was a finalist in multiple international tournaments as well as the LSE IV champion. Since 2020 she has been a debating coach in numerous high schools and faculties. As an Open Communication board member, she organized and coordinated dozen debating events. Currently, she is a project assistant and trainer in numerous projects such as the MICC project (Model International Criminal Court) and DARE project (Depolarization Activism for Resilient Europe) where she is the lead of the creative team, and in charge of video editing, animation, and graphic design.

For the last 2 years Lazar has been a member of the executive board of Open Communication, which is responsible for organizing debating competitions, teaching high school and university students how to debate, and nurturing the culture of dialogue through variety of projects. He's also been a debater in British Parliamentary format since 2019. And during his debating career he has been successful both on a national as well as on an international level. Some of his notable achievements are Belgrade WUDC 2022 ESL Quarterfinalist, Belgrade Open 2022 Champion, Ljubljana IV 2022 Champion, Doxbridge Pre Wudc ESL Champion.
He's also been a core member for organizing national and regional debating competitions, and assisted in the organization of Belgrade WUDC 2022.

LAZAR POPOVIĆ (SERBIA) – LOGISTICS OFFICER

SANJA KUZMANOVSKI (SERBIA) - VOLUNTEERS OFFICER

Sanja Kuzmanovski is an experienced and dedicated organizer, having served as the Debate Coordinator at Open Communication and a Local Coordinator for the Anne Frank House traveling exhibition. She has also been a part of the organizing team for various debating events, including Novi Sad EUDC 2018 and the recent Zagreb EUDC 2022. Sanja's attention to detail, effective communication skills, and ability to work under pressure make her a valuable asset to any organizing team.

Ognjen is a second-generation lawyer who commenced his law practice immediately upon completing his studies at the University of Belgrade in 2018. As a student, he achieved notable success in national and international debating competitions, including being awarded EFL Top Speaker at WUDC 2017 and a victory in the ESL category at Oxford IV 2016. Additionally, he has played an instrumental role in the development of the Serbian word schools debating program, having served as a coach for Team Serbia during the Zagreb WSDC, which played a significant role in popularizing the format in Serbia. In November 2022 he directed the organization of Kragujevac Open in his hometown. It was the largest ever national debating event in Serbia organized outside of capital city of Belgrade. Ognjen is the current reigning national debating champion, having triumphed in the highly competitive tournament in 2022, nearly four years after his last competitive speech!

OGNJEN MILADINOVIĆ (SERBIA) – SOCIALS OFFICER

ADVISORY BOARD

SHARMILA PARMANAND - CHIEF ADJUDICATION ADVISOR

MILOŠ MARJANOVIĆ (SERBIA) - CONVENING ADVISOR

ANASTAZIJA STUPAR (CROATIA) - CONVENING ADVISOR

JOSHUA PARK (KOREA) - TAB ADVISOR

TECK WEI TAN (SINGAPORE) - CHIEF ADJUDICATION ADVISOR

DRAFT BUDGET - ZERO SPONSORSHIP & 515 PARTICIPANTS (50-55 TEAMS)*

EXPENDITURES	ACCOMMODATION	34.966.473 RSD	297.587 EUR	327.345 USD
	LUNCH	3.249.815 RSD	27.658 EUR	30.423 USD
	LOGISTICS	1.762.500 RSD	15.000 EUR	16.500 USD
	ADMINISTRATION & ORGANIZATION	1.351.250 RSD	11.500 EUR	12.650,00 USD
	MATERIALS	*705.000 RSD*	*6.000 EUR*	*6.600 USD*
	MEDIA COVERAGE	*293.750 RSD*	*2.500 EUR*	*2.750 USD*
	BANK FEES	*117.500 RSD*	*1.000 EUR*	*1.100 USD*
	MISCELLANEOUS	*235.000 RSD*	*2.000 EUR*	*2.200 USD*
	NON-PAYING PARTICIPANTS (15) - ALL COSTS	1.786.000 RSD	15.200 EUR	16.720 USD
	OPENING/CLOSING CEREMONIES & SOCIALS	1.175.000 RSD	10.000 EUR	11.000 USD
	AWARDS BUDGET	352.500 RSD	3.000 EUR	3.300 USD
	IA FUNDING	1.175.000 RSD	10.000 EUR	11.000 USD
	CONTINGENCY	1.175.000 RSD	10.000 EUR	11.000,00 USD
	TOTAL EXPENDITURES	**46.993.538 RSD**	**399.945 EUR**	**439.939 USD**
INCOME	PARTICIPATION FEES (500)	47.000.000 RSD	400.000 EUR	440.000 USD
	TOTAL INCOME	**47.000.000 RSD**	**400.000 EUR**	**440.000 USD**

**Based on approximated numbers from previous championships, we expect this to be the most plausible budget. Also, following are only sample budgets, team cap of our bid is 80 teams.*

DRAFT BUDGET – ZERO SPONSORSHIP & 465 PARTICIPANTS (45-50 TEAMS)

EXPENDITURES	ACCOMMODATION	31.469.790 RSD	267.828 EUR	294.610 USD
	LUNCH	2.924.693 RSD	24.891 EUR	27.380 USD
	LOGISTICS	1.410.000 RSD	12.000 EUR	13.200 USD
	ADMINISTRATION & ORGANIZATION	1.233.750 RSD	10.500 EUR	11.550 USD
	MATERIALS	*587.500 RSD*	*5.000 EUR*	*5.500 USD*
	MEDIA COVERAGE	*293.750 RSD*	*2.500 EUR*	*2.750 USD*
	BANK FEES	*117.500 RSD*	*1.000 EUR*	*1.100 USD*
	MISCELLANEOUS	*235.000 RSD*	*2.000 EUR*	*2.200 USD*
	NON-PAYING PARTICIPANTS (15) – ALL COSTS	1.586.250 RSD	13.500 EUR	14.850 USD
	OPENING/CLOSING CEREMONIES & SOCIALS	1.175.000 RSD	10.000 EUR	11.000 USD
	AWARDS BUDGET	352.500 RSD	3.000 EUR	3.300 USD
	IA FUNDING	1.175.000 RSD	10.000 EUR	11.000 USD
	CONTINGENCY	940.000 RSD	8.000 EUR	8.800 USD
	TOTAL EXPENDITURES	**42.266.983 RSD**	**359.719 EUR**	**395.690 USD**
INCOME	PARTICIPATION FEES (450)	42.300.000 RSD	360.000 EUR	396.000 USD
	TOTAL INCOME	**42.300.000 RSD**	**360.000 EUR**	**396.000 USD**

DRAFT BUDGET – ZERO SPONSORSHIP & 390 PARTICIPANTS (40-45 TEAMS)

EXPENDITURES	ACCOMODATION	26.224.825 RSD	223.190 EUR	245.509 USD
	LUNCH	2.437.303 RSD	20.743 EUR	22.817 USD
	LOGISTICS	940.000 RSD	8.000 EUR	8.800 USD
	ADMINISTRATION & ORGANIZATION	1.057.500 RSD	9.000 EUR	9.900 USD
	MATERIALS	*470.000 RSD*	*4.000 EUR*	*4.400 USD*
	MEDIA COVERAGE	*293.750 RSD*	*2.500 EUR*	*2.750 USD*
	BANK FEES	*117.500 RSD*	*1.000 EUR*	*1.100 USD*
	MISCELLANEOUS	*176.250 RSD*	*1.500 EUR*	*1.650 USD*
	NON-PAYING PARTICIPANTS (15) – ALL COSTS	1.410.000 RSD	12.000 EUR	13.200 USD
	OPENING/CLOSING CEREMONIES & SOCIALS	881.250 RSD	7.500 EUR	8.250 USD
	AWARDS BUDGET	352.500 RSD	3.000 EUR	3.300 USD
	IA FUNDING	1.175.000 RSD	10.000 EUR	11.000 USD
	CONTINGENCY	763.750 RSD	6.500 EUR	7.150 USD
	TOTAL EXPENDITURES	**35.242.157 RSD**	**299.933 EUR**	**329.926 USD**
INCOME	PARTICIPATION FEES (375)	35.250.000 RSD	300.000 EUR	330.000 USD
	TOTAL INCOME	**35.250.000 RSD**	**300.000 EUR**	**330.000 USD**

DRAFT BUDGET - CLARIFICATIONS

Accomodation covers 10 nights at the Crowne Plaza Belgrade hotel with buffet style breakfast.

Food covers lunches and dinners for all participants during preliminary rounds days and lunches and dinners for participants debating in out rounds for the days of them. That being said, every participant will get at least 4 lunches and 4 dinners and for every day participant is debating or judging in out rounds they will be provided with lunch and dinner. Also, every participant will be provided dinner at opening and closing ceremonies.* We commit to provide diverse food with good nutritional content and to honor every dietary requirement.

Transport part of the budget covers all transport from accommodation to the venues and social activities and back to the accommodation.

IA budget is expected to cover reg waivers and/or cost of travel for paid IAs.

**Meals at the opening and closing ceremonies are in included in socials budget*.

DRAFT BUDGET - ACCESSIBILITY

In the process of budget preparation, we have tried to adopt a conservative approach and accounted for a worst-case scenario that entails a reduced number of participants (375) and a complete absence of sponsorships. However, since the number of participants is likely to be higher, we are attaching budgets for those scenarios as well.

We understand that 800 EUR participation fee is considerably higher than the registration fees of some of the most recent in-person World Schools Debating Championships. However, this is a registration fee that ensures a high quality competition even in the unlikely case of us being unable to secure any sponsorship deals. Serbia, just like the rest of Europe, was severely impacted the high inflation and Belgrade is experiencing a major tourist boom, which means that the prices for accommodation and food have increased significantly in the past few years.

A fact worth mentioning when comparing costs with Croatia and Slovenia WSDC in Zagreb in 2018 is that the average consumer prices went up by almost 30%, and the most relevant costs for the tournament as accommodation and food went up by almost 35% (calculation is done by using Harmonised Index of Consumer Prices by European Central Bank and with various projections from Serbian and Croatian central banks).

Our team is committed to securing both private and government sponsorships, and we will spare no effort in achieving this goal. Drawing upon our extensive alumni network developed over the past 25 years, we are confident in our ability to secure the necessary sponsorships. We are optimistic that our network will provide us with the necessary support to ensure our success We understand the importance of keeping the community informed about our progress and pledge to provide regular updates if our bid is successful. Our aim is to utilise sponsorship funds to decrease the participation fee. Drawing upon our successful track record in securing sponsorships for previous major events we have organised, we are confident that we can achieve this goal.

ACCOMMODATION – CROWNE PLAZA HOTEL BELGRADE

Crowne Plaza is a global hotel chain. Crowne Plaza Hotel Belgrade is a 4* grand hotel with 416 rooms, located in the central business district of New Belgrade. It is only 13 km from the International Belgrade Airport Nikola Tesla and only 5 minutes driving distance from the city center. The hotel is equipped with modern spas and fitness facilities and the biggest hotel pool in the whole country. Also, it offers a business center (facilities include copying, printing, and ATMs). Crowne Plaza Belgrade offers the highest level of service and free Wi-Fi throughout the hotel. **Participants will be accommodated in double and triple rooms with buffet-service breakfast at the hotel.**

VENUE – FACULTY OF ORGANIZATIONAL SCIENCES BELGRADE

Faculty of Organizational Sciences is one of the leading higher education institutions in the region with the tradition of over 40 years. In the period of intensive changes it became leading education and research institution in the field of organizational sciences, management, informational systems and technologies. Faculty today has over 3500 students on 18 different study programmes on undergraduate, graduate and postgraduate level of studies. Given the long tradition of cooperation of Open Communication with the University of Belgrade and Faculty of Organizational Sciences, we propose this venue as it is fully equipped for large-scale debate championships for up to 80 teams and located in a calm part of the city.

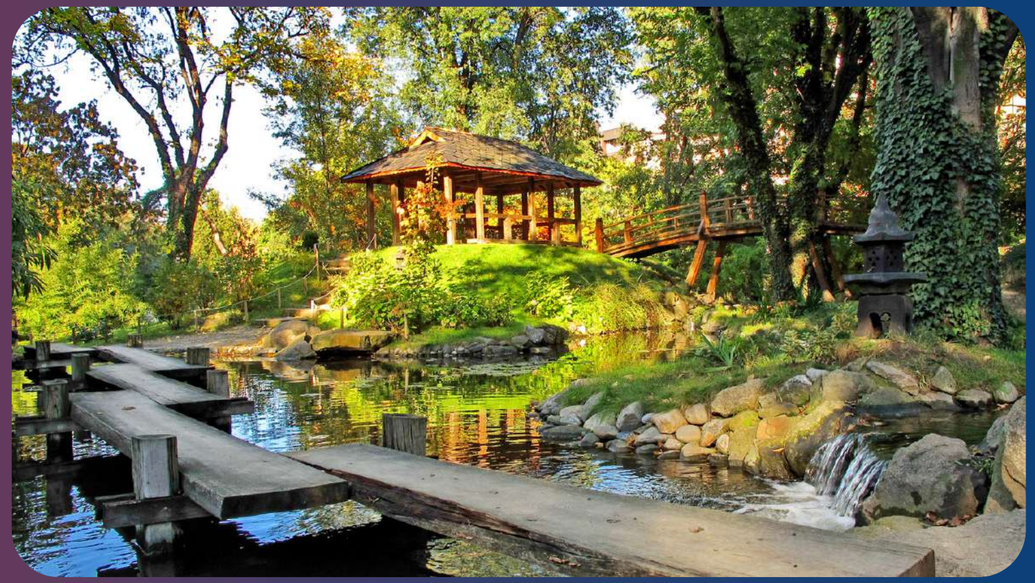
OPENING CEREMONY - ILIJA M. KOLARAC ENDOWMENT

Ilija M. Kolarac Endowment, also known as the Kolarac People's University Building, is in the historical city centre of Belgrade. The building is a monument of a great cultural and historical importance and as such was declared as the immovable cultural property.

CLOSING CEREMONY – JEVREMOVAC BOTANICAL GARDEN

Botanical Garden "Jevremovac" is a unit of the Faculty of Biology, University of Belgrade. It was founded in 1874 by the decision of the Ministry of Education of the Kingdom of Serbia, at the suggestion of Josif Pančić, who was also its first manager. In 1889, King Milan Obrenović donated the estate (which he inherited from his grandfather Jevrem) to the Great School in Belgrade for the Botanical Garden, but on the condition that it be called "Jevremovac". It is still in that place and under that name today.

The botanical garden covers an area of about 5 hectares, where there are more than 350 types of trees and bushes, domestic, European and exotic plants in the open space, and the total plant fund today consists of over 1500 trees, bushes and herbaceous plants. In addition to open areas, the Botanical Garden includes the Glass Garden and the premises of the Institute of Botany (administrative building, herbarium, library, auditorium, laboratories).



COST OF TRAVEL

Belgrade is a well-connected city with direct flights to four continents including New York, Chicago and Beijing and the biggest hubs in the Middle East and Europe. Belgrade Airport Nikola Tesla will be upgraded with a new terminal by the summer of 2024 and is expected to be able to accommodate up to 10 million passengers annually. Below you can see a list of return flights from particular cities during the summer season. Also, near Belgrade, there are a couple of cities with airports that can offer cheaper flight tickets. Those are Nis, Zagreb, Timisoara, Budapest and Sarajevo. They are approximately 5-6 hours away from Belgrade by bus.

COST OF TRAVEL

ASIA
Bangkok $1230 on Turkish Airlines (1stop)
Shanghai $1327 on Qatar Airways (1 stop)
Singapore $1302 on Emirates (1 stop)
Tokyo $1675 on Emirates (1 stop)
Seoul $1284 on Turkish Airlines (1 stop)

AFRICA
Cairo $330 on Air Serbia (1 stop)
Cape Town $997 on Lufthansa (2 stops)
Johannesburg $970 on Turkish Airlines (1 stop)

MIDDLE EAST
Doha $678 on Pegasus (1 stop)
Tel Aviv $254 on Austrian Airlines (1 stop)

OCEANIA
Auckland $2130 on Qatar Airways (2 stops)
Melbourne $2383 on Qatar Airways (1 stop)
Sydney $2191 on Air France (2 stops)

AMERICAS
Atlanta $1576 on Lufthansa (2 stops)
Boston $1510 on Air Canada+Swiss (2 stops)
Buenos Aires $2157 on Emirates (1 stop)
Los Angeles $1207 on LOT Polish Airlines (1 stop)
Mexico City $1513 on Air Canada+Austrian Airlines (2 stops)
New York $1311 on Air Serbia (non stop)
Seattle $1622 on Swiss Airlines+Lufthansa (2 stops)
Toronto $1329 on LOT Polish Airlines (1 stop)
Vancouver $1620 on Delta Airlines+Air France (1 stop)

EUROPE
Amsterdam $339 on KLM (non stop)
Athens $189 on Air Serbia (non stop)
Barcelona $277 on Lufthansa (1 stop)
Berlin $227 on Lufthansa (1 stop)
Dublin $309 on Lufthansa (1 stop)
Glasgow $353 on Lufthansa (1 stop)
London $202 on Lufthansa (1 stop)
Paris $264 on Air France (non stop)
Prague $243 on Air Serbia (non stop)
Riga $348 on LOT Polish Airlines (1 stop)
Rome $202 on Air Serbia (non stop)
Vienna $198 on Air Serbia (non stop)

ENTRY REQUIREMENTS – VISA REGIME & COVID RESTRICTIONS

Serbia has one of the most liberal visa polices in Europe, thus enabling delegates from both EU and non-EU countries to attend the Serbia WSDC 2024 without any visa procedure issues and additional costs.

Citizens of the following countries do not need to obtain visas:

- Citizens of the following may enter the Republic of Serbia using their identity cards and stay up to 90 days: European Union countries, Bosnia and Herzegovina, Iceland, Macedonia, Montenegro, Norway and Switzerland
- Nationals of (provided they hold a valid passport): Albania, Belarus, Israel, Russian Federation, Turkey and Ukraine. Rest of world: Argentina, Australia, Bolivia, Brazil, Canada, Chile, PR China (for stays up to 30 days; for Chinese citizens holders of SAR Macau and SAR Hong Kong passports visa is not required for stays up to 90 and 14 days, respectively), Costa Rica, Japan, Kazakhstan, Kuwait, Mexico, New Zealand, Republic of Korea, Seychelles, Singapore, Tunisia, United States of America, Uruguay
- Nationals provided they are holding diplomatic and official passports, or ordinary passports indicating they are travelling on business: Algeria, Armenia, Azerbaijan, DPR Korea, Ecuador, Egypt, Georgia, Guinea, India, Iran, Moldova, Mongolia, Morocco, Pakistan, Peru, Tajikistan and Turkmenistan, Venezuela, Vietnam
- Delegates holding a valid Schengen, UK and other EU Member States' visa, or a visa of the United States of America, are able to enter Serbia without any additional visa procedures. The visa regime has recently been even more liberalised for 10 additional countries, a trend that Serbia will follow in the coming years.

Nationals of other countries will need to obtain a visa by meeting the following requirements:
- Valid Passport
- One of the following: a letter of invitation (verified by the appropriate Serbian authority), an invitation from a company for a business visit, a receipt or authorised tourist company certifying that the travel arrangement has been paid (letter of credit or other payment receipt)
- Return ticket
- Proof of sufficient funds
- Health Insurance
- Completed visa application, photo, visA fee

No COVID related requirements are needed at the moment, and all restrictions regarding COVID (wearing masks; bans on mass gatherings) are no longer in place in Serbia.

VISA REQUIREMENTS

Citizens of countries who require a visa to enter Serbia can expect to be asked to present the following documents: proof of sufficient funds, proof of a health insurance, return flight ticket, a photo, a completed visa application form and a letter of invitation.

The Ministry of Foreign Affairs of the Republic of Serbia has committed to offer support and advice in the visa application process for the participants of the WSDC 2024, should Serbia be chosen to host the competition. They have given us the following clarifications regarding some of the documents required when applying for a Serbian visa:

1) Proof of sufficient funds is a bank statement about funds on a bank account issued on the name of the visa applier. Each individual, in order to be given a visa to enter Serbia must prove that they posses at least 50 EUR (55 USD) for each day of their visit to Serbia. In cases where accommodation and food costs are covered in advance (for example through a registration fee to attend an event), this requirement can be relaxed (required amount lowered) or altogether withdrawn at the the discretion of the Ministry of Foreign Affairs of the Republic of Serbia.

2) Required Health insurance is a basic travel health insurance which would cover potential injuries or other unwanted events. Although there is no minimum requirement, the recommended covered amount is at least 20.000 EUR.

3) Letters of invitation can be issued by the proposed convenors of the Serbia WSDC 2024, Open Communication.

WHAT TO DO IN BELGRADE?

FOOD

Serbia is known for its magnificent traditional cuisine. Serbian cuisine is one of the most unique in the world, presenting the fusion of tastes and texture. The national dishes include gibanica (egg and cheese pie), pljeskavica (a ground beef/pork patty), cevapi (grilled ground meat), and sarma (spiced up minced meat which is rolled in sour cabbage leafs). With Serbia being located on the crossroads between East and West, its cuisine has gathered elements from different cooking styles across the Middle East and Europe to develop its own hearty gastronomy with an intricate balance of rich meats, vegetables, breads, cheese, fresh pastries and desserts.

CULTURE

Serbian culture has a very rich folklore, which consists of national traditions and customs, traditional costumes which differ from one region to another, folk dances, and songs. Thanks to its eventful history, Serbia has a variety of cultural and architectural monuments - medieval monasteries with their fresco paintings and beautiful icons, mosques, medieval and Austro-Hungarian fortresses, baroque churches. Citizens of Serbia are very sociable and outgoing, and they tend to be very open, so visitors shouldn't be hesitant to ask someone for directions or places to go, they will most likely help you in the best way they possibly can.

The main pedestrian street and shopping zone Knez Mihailova street is the most dynamic street in Belgrade. Every step of this 800m street hosts cafes and restaurants, shops of world-famous brands, street performers and outdoor art expositions. This old street was called in 1870 after Prince Mihailo Obrenović, ruler that was assassinated two years before. Belgrade is famously known as a city that never sleeps. One of the most popular and unique places to visit is the "kafana" that is a type of local bistro that often features live music performances.

TRADITION - SAINT SAVA TEMPLE

St. Sava Temple is the world's second biggest Orthodox Church. It carries its name after Sava, a Serbian monk from the 13th century, the founder of the Serbian Orthodox Church and its first archbishop. The temple stands on Vracar hill, on a place where in the 16th century the Ottomans have burned St. Sava's bones as a sign of their power. The construction of the temple began in 1935 and was finished in 2022. The Nazi invasion of Belgrade in 1941 and then decades of communist regime were the main obstacles to its earlier completion. It's told that Serbian Patriarch German had to send 88 requests to the authorities before the continuation of the building. St. Sava Temple is visible from almost every part of Belgrade and it carries the intriguing story about the struggle of Serbian people throughout the centuries.

SCIENCE - NIKOLA TESLA MUSEUM

One of the people Serbs are most proud of is Nikola Tesla - the brilliant Serbian-American inventor, engineer and futurist, most famous for developing modern alternating current electricity system. Tesla was also a pioneer in the discovery of X-ray technology, radar, remote control, electric coil and radio. As if that's not enough, the world's most awesome electric car is named after him. The Nikola Tesla Museum contains all sorts of documents, books, drawings and photographs related to Tesla's work. There are also interesting interactive exhibitions displaying some of Tesla's inventions. Students and science enthusiasts will be especially delighted to explore his work. Inside the museum you will also find a strange, golden orb. That's an urn containing Nikola Tesla's ashes, a subject of continuous debate between the museum and the Orthodox Church - which argues that his remains ought to be properly buried. There are guided tours available in Serbian and English.

LETTER OF ENDORSEMENT

SLOVENIAN NATIONAL DEBATE ORGANISATION
ZA IN PROTI, ZAVOD ZA KULTURO DIALOGA

ZA IN PROTI, ZAVOD ZA KULTURO DIALOGA
Svetosavska 24, 1000 Ljubljana
www.zainproti.com, www.zainproti.si
info@zainproti.si

Ljubljana, 17. april 2023

Letter of Endorsement

Za in proti, zavod za kulturo dialoga, the Slovenian national debate organisation expresses its full and enthusiastic support for the *Otvorena Komunikacija's* bid to host the World Schools Debating Championship (WSDC) 2024 in Belgrade, Serbia. Our two organisations, both established in 1997, have been fruitfully collaborating since the very beginning, together shaping the development of the debate circuit in the region and creating lasting bonds between Slovenian and Serbian debaters and youth workers.

If the bid is successful, we have no doubt that Serbia WSDC 2024 will be a fantastic experience for debaters from around the globe as well as a great opportunity for the future growth of popularity of high school debate in the region. We are proud to have our very own Rok Hafner as one of the two proposed Chief Adjudicators and we are committed to offer *Otvorena Komunikacija* our full support in hosting the event.

Peter Mesarec
Director
Za in proti, zavod za kulturo dialoga

ZA IN PROTI-ZAVOD ZA KULTURO DIALOGA LJUBLJANA

WE HOPE TO SEE
YOU IN BELGRADE!
WSDC
2024
SERBIA